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Do You Want to See the Truth?

Visual Novels and Creative Nonfiction: An Unlikely Marriage

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“The art challenges the technology, and the technology inspires the art.”

- John Lasseter

Welcome, dear reader. I am your author; your narrator; your merchant. Should you choose to entertain the following ramblings, I shall attempt to sell you an idea; a single question — a question that I, myself, am unsure how to answer:

Do you want to see the truth?

“I do!” - [Continue reading].

“I don’t!” - [Turn to page 7].

...

“I do!”

So, you want to see the truth? You wish to see an author’s memoirs poeticized on-screen? Then come! A new era approaches the literary world, so we must make haste. Relish in this *choose-your-own-adventure* — on the digital implications of choosing your own adventure. This will be an exploration of a potential marriage; between a timeless genre and a modern format: *Creative nonfiction* (CNF) and the *visual novel* (VN). Their pairing may seem unlikely for the moment, but alas, there is no sense in fretting over the matter: You have already made your choice.

A visual novel is a digital narrative format. It aims to enhance the genre of fiction — or so says the likes of Wikipedia¹. Others believe VNs to be a format analogous to video games², as they offer the reader narrative choices on-screen. In earnest, I hold these two ideas to be true, but not the whole truth. There is still something hiding within this new medium that we have yet to see. In my eyes, visual novels are a format that can champion any type of literary genre, style, or narrative. Moreover, I believe VNs to hold a seldom discussed and largely untapped potential in terms of their pairing with CNF. But with that belief comes the necessity to question if they are right for each other. So then, dear reader, since the direction you want to take this conversation matters to me:

Where would you like to go now?

“How might VNs enhance CNF?” - [Turn to page 4].

“How might VNs harm CNF?” - [Continue reading].

...

“How might VNs harm CNF?”

As we’ve discussed, VNs provide readers with digitally interactive choices at every turn. Through these choices, many different narrative branches can be explored — each leading to their own unique outcomes. A standout example comes from an indie title: *BAD END THEATER*³, published and developed by NomnomNami. *BAD END THEATER* forces readers to choose which characters will perform in a play — a play seemingly directed by the author’s fictitious persona. The outcomes for both the characters and the narrative are heavily influenced

¹ https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Visual_novel

² <https://www.masterclass.com/articles/visual-novels-explained-plus-notable-visual-novel-video-games>

³ https://store.steampowered.com/app/1764390/BAD_END_THEATER/

by the reader's input. Should they choose, for instance, to pick the character named “Underling” and influence their actions throughout the narrative, the Underling will experience one of many different endings. You could have the Underling kill the story’s hero. You could have them depart from their allies, choosing instead to live their days in solitude. In essence, *you* choose the Underling’s fate, and in turn, the direction of the story.

With this in mind, it’s easy to see why VNs pair naturally with fiction. Thanks to the element of VN interactivity, the characters of *BAD END THEATER* can live multiple lives in multiple timelines — but the author of *BAD END THEATER* cannot. Does this mean that an author of CNF can’t infuse their own memoirs with VN interactivity? Are CNF readers barred from experiencing their works in such a way? Let’s push on, and challenge this notion.

Consider the following CNF piece: *We Regret to Inform You* by Brenda Miller⁴. The piece takes us through an author’s pursuit for acceptance, and the narrative is structured as a string of rejection letters. If you were to read the original piece, you would experience each letter in the way that the author intended (which is essential). But if the piece were adapted into a VN, the author could enhance the reader’s engagement with each letter. What if, on-screen, the letters arrived to the reader unopened? What if they were shown in the exact same order, packaged in tightly sealed envelopes, disclosing only the date and the sender’s name on the front? What if the reader were given the *choice* to open each? Giving the reader these freedoms through this format would allow for a deeper connection with the content while preserving the structure on which it stands. If a reader, for instance, were to open each letter, it would strengthen the feeling of being in the author’s shoes. If they choose to keep a letter unopened, it may prompt the reader, in their own minds, to ask themselves why. Perhaps a certain envelope, or the name of a certain sender, reminded them of a time when *they* felt rejected. Perhaps they weren't ready to unpack those

⁴ <https://www.thesunmagazine.org/issues/455/we-regret-to-inform-you>

feelings. Perhaps, in that moment, their feelings would reflect the same emotions that the author wished to convey in the first place. In this way, the VN format would fortify this piece of creative nonfiction without destroying it.

Where would you like to go now?

“How might VNs enhance CNF?” - [Continue reading].

The End - [Turn to page 8].

...

“How might VNs enhance CNF?”

One way involves the actions you just took. You read through your options, chose your path, and turned the page. You interacted with this piece of creative nonfiction at a fundamental level. For some, this may have been engaging; scratching their itch for agency within a piece. For others, this was dull, as tracking down the content you want to read can be rather tedious. You’re forced to pause and scramble through these pages. It may, for a moment, have removed you from the piece. Is there a way to remedy this discrepancy among readers? Is it possible to enhance your interactivity, without breaking the traditions of CNF? Let’s unpack the issue together.

Visual novels take readers through a digital, text-heavy, on-screen narrative; oftentimes with accompanying videos or images. They provide the same choices you’re involved with right now while removing the tedium of scrambling through pages. You can *touch* or *click* the path you desire, and the VN will progress the narrative in an instant. No longer are you subject to the

dreaded pause, or any other text you weren't interested in. There's a caveat, though: It's presented in pixels.

Understandably, this may be enough to discourage authors and readers. But if you feel this is you, ask yourself this: Why do we read on paper in the first place? Well, for one, it's just plain fun. The blissful scent of a freshly printed page is an undoubtedly universal experience. But up until recent history, we've read works from paper out of necessity. For centuries, we've needed ways to produce and consume physical information on a global scale. In 1436, Johannes Gutenberg (among others before him)⁵ gave us a way — with the invention of the moveable printing press. It helped spark the traditions of reading we practice today. But no tradition is truly immune to the flow of time. From the invention of the CRT display in the 1930s⁶ to the mobile user interfaces that dominate the present, the ways we read text have always been evolving. Given this, is the marriage of VNs and CNF really that unnatural?

While we're on the act of reading, there's another factor we need to account for if we plan to marry these mediums: *The ways we naturally read*. Though we all see the same text on the page, each and every one of us reads those words differently. Because of this, authors must consider the form in which the text is delivered. It's a matter of accessibility, and it will make or break the reader's experience. At this point, some of you reading may feel wholly drained by this essay. It can be exhausting to read a wall of text, only to move on to the next, and the next. Some of us (myself included) may find mental imagery an effortful task, and as a result, all we end up reading are words. Our minds may play tricks on us; sequence the switching of words in a sentence. Visual novels can address these issues, within and beyond creative nonfiction.

⁵ <https://www.history.com/news/printing-press-renaissance>

⁶

<https://www.ledsmagazine.com/sponsored/flex-lighting/article/16701781/evolution-of-device-display-technology>

VNs not only offer visuals, but motion images; ranging from an image that hovers from left to right to a fully hand-drawn animation. If used wisely, moving images can complement the text in CNF, without diluting the narrative's truth. They ensure that all readers can grasp the author's narrative since they're given different ways to understand it: Through pictures and through text. If you happen to miss a story detail in-text, you could look at the speaker or the scene on-screen, and obtain the narrative context you need. Let's apply this to an existing piece of creative nonfiction: Sei Shōnagon's *Hateful Things*⁷ — an ancient and legendary rant on the author's many animosities. In this 10th-century memoir, Shōnagon wrote the following passage:

“A newcomer pushes ahead of the other members in a group; with a knowing look, this person starts laying down the law and forcing advice upon everyone—most hateful.”

If the reader's mind were elsewhere while scanning this sentence, they may decide to move on without re-reading it; losing information in the process. But if there were an image in movement on-screen, they would have another chance to digest the content. Their chances grow tenfold if both the text and visuals are paired with an active choice. Imagine if the reader were forced to agree or disagree with Shōnagon's statement. If they choose the latter, the author could respond with something cheeky— a disgusted expression, paired with the words “YOU ARE MOST HATEFUL” in scarily large text. The author themselves, of course, cannot do this, on account of the fact that they are dead, but it's something worth considering for modern writers.

Where would you like to go now?

“How might VNs harm CNF?” - [Turn to page 2].

The End - [Turn to page 8].

⁷ <https://www.basicincome.com/bp/hatefulthings.htm>

...

“I don’t!”

And that, dear reader, is more than okay. In this seemingly post-truth era of information, where words beg for your attention at every turn, it’s essential that you feel control over the content you want to read. In the genre of creative nonfiction, it’s especially crucial you have a say in the narratives you want to digest, for one person’s truth may look different than another’s. By structuring this CNF piece in this format (a choose-your-own-adventure), one of my aims is that no matter which options you choose, you come out of this feeling like you had a sense of agency. Choosing “*I don’t*” may feel no different from closing your browser, or putting the paper down. But by framing this decision as an interactive choice, maybe you can feel your own form of closure. Thus, if you wish to depart from this essay, I shall now close my eyes, and let you walk away...

... You’re still here? I’m glad! It’d feel a little lonely writing to no one, and this makes for a chance to highlight one of the most important things about CNF, and its potential fusion with visual novels: *The enhancement of the conversational tone.*

For the uninitiated: The conversational tone is an element of CNF that invites interactions between the author and reader. It requires my words to be addressed to *you*, as opposed to the nameless ears of the void. In the same way your presence makes me a happy writer, my acknowledgment of you makes you a happy reader. For who is going to listen if they are not first spoken to?

Visual novels, within the realms of CNF, have the power to amplify this tone. Currently, I speak to you in text and text alone. But what if you could see me, or an idea of me, as you read? Have you ever envisioned the faces of Seneca as he wrote to Lucilius? And if we were to see

them within a VN, would his works really lose their literary form? Would it lose the element of truth that makes it nonfiction? It seems that it wouldn't, as the depictions of Seneca would compliment his words, and the words themselves would remain untouched. It would embolden the aspects that make it creative while protecting the truths that make it nonfiction. Having said this, though, there are still other facets of the visual novel that may or may not compromise this genre, and forgo its traditions. Thus, dear reader, allow me to ask:

Where would you like to go now?

“How might VNs enhance CNF?” - [Turn to page 4].

“How might VNs harm CNF?” - [Turn to page 2].

The End - [Continue reading].

...

The End

Or is it the beginning? Are we in the dawn of a new literary era, dear reader? Will the wheel of fate continue to turn, as genre and form blend once more? Are they to be married? To live happily ever after? Or will the traditions of nonfiction continue to stand the test of time? The answers may be uncertain for now, but the question remains:

Do you want to see the truth?

...

The choice is yours.

Word Count: 2,187